Thinai (tract)-based Sangam Society

The land form was divided into five *thinai*s (eco-regions).

Eco-region (*thinai*)	Landscape	Occupation	People	Deity
Kurinji	Hilly region	Hunting /gathering	Kuravar/kurathiyar	Murugan
Mullai	Forest region	Herding	Aayar/aaichiyar	Maayon
Marutham	Riverine track (plains)	Agriculture	Uzhavan/uzhathiyar	Indiran
Neithal	Coastal region	Fishing/saltmaking	Parathavar/ nulathiyar	Varunan
Palai	Parched land	Heroic deeds	Maravar/Marathiyar	Kotravai

Land was classified according to its fertility. Marutham was called *menpulam* (fertile land). It produced paddy and sugarcane. The rest of the landscape, excluding Neithal, was called *vanpulam* (hard land), and it produced pulses and dry grains.

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Status of Women

There was no restriction for women in social life. There were learned and wise women. Forty women poets had lived and left behind their valuable works. Marriage was a matter of self-choice. However, chastity (*karpu)* was considered the highest virtue of women. Sons and daughters had equal shares in their parents' property.

Women Poets of Sangam Age

Avvaiyar, Velli Veethiyar, Kakkaipadiniyar, Aathi Manthiyar, Pon Mudiyar.

Religious Beliefs and Social Divisions

The primary deity of the Tamils was Seyon or Murugan. Other gods worshipped during Sangam period were Sivan, Mayon (Vishnu), Indiran, Varunan and Kotravai. The Hero stone (*natukkal*) worship was in practice. Buddhism and Jainism also co-existed.

Veerakkal / Natukkal

The ancient Tamils had a great respect for the heroes who died in the battle field. The hero stones were erected to commemorate heroes who sacrificed their lives in war.



Caste did not develop in Tamizhagam as it did in the northern India. Varuna system (occupation-based caste) came to the Dravidian south comparatively late.

Dress and Ornaments

The rich people wore muslin, silk and fine cotton garments. The common

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